



Write a Top 1% Resume

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Golden Idea

This is why a resume is important and step-by-step how to create an incredible software engineering resume.

Importance

What's the main reason this idea is important to understand?

- Your resume is the first gate into landing a software engineering job, so it's extremely important and impactful. One of the very first things you should do when embarking on this journey is to **optimize your resume** as much as you possibly can.
- Resumes *drastically* impact not only your interview/OA to application ratio but also deeply help with referrals, research, clubs, etc. Your resume is **EVERYTHING**, and you must treat it with the **time and attention it deserves**.

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Introduction

It's probably the single greatest lever in the world of software engineering job acquisition, bar none. With a great resume, you'll eventually find a job, and **with a terrible resume, no matter how great you are at interviewing you'll be out of luck**.

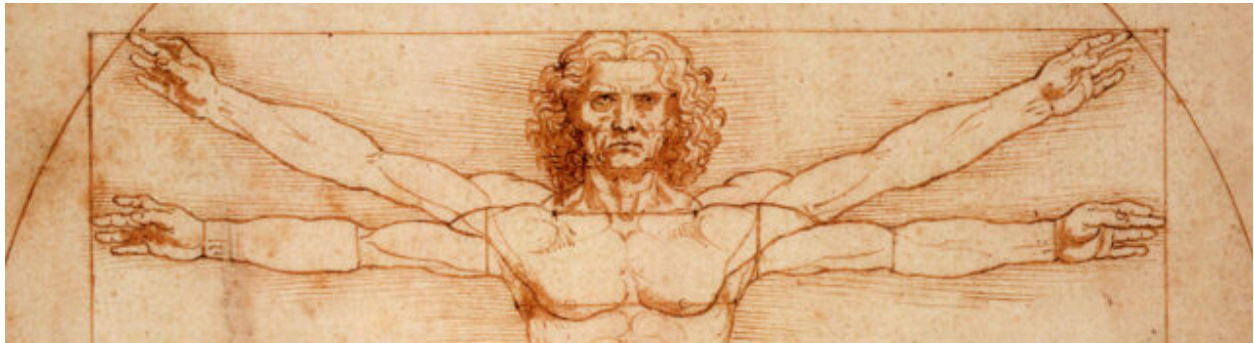
My story with resumes: I always had a pretty solid resume, and I genuinely believed that really contributed to a lot of my internship success in the long run. **I never neglected my resume.**

The transformation: *From current resume to top 1% resume.*

The purpose of this video and following assignment is to take your resume and make it a top 1% resume. I want you to watch this video in full **with your resume right next to**

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you, and then rewatch it as you go through and completely update/revamp your resume, before you submit it to us for review.



Resume Fundamentals

History and function of resumes:

Leonardo da Vinci (1482): The first recorded resume is attributed to Leonardo da Vinci, who wrote a letter to the Duke of Milan seeking employment. This letter highlighted his skills and capabilities, akin to a modern resume.

Purpose and importance:

To an employer, you are your resume. Your resume is you in a piece of paper, and off of just that they decide whether you're worth talking to or not. Until your resume passes the screen, you have no shot.

You spend a few hours once/month, and you get tons of results. Resumes fall into the category of asymmetric activities.

Every input in the software engineering job acquisition process starts with your resume — every single one.

Instructions: Download [this](#) resource, and go through and check off all the features you've already implemented as you watch this video. So one by one, pause the video, think about it, and check it off if you've done it.

- Be objective + critical — DO NOT be lazy here. You probably think your resume is good, but honestly, most likely it's not.

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- When you're done, go through all the unchecked boxes and revamp your resume using those principles as part of the assignment.



🏆 High-Level Principles

Make your resume as impressive as you can defend.

- Exaggeration here is okay. Don't lie, but be as outlandish as you can. *Be as outrageous as you can defend.*

Rank choice order: Arrange elements from most to least impressive

In your resume, here are the options you have to work with, in order of **best → worst**:

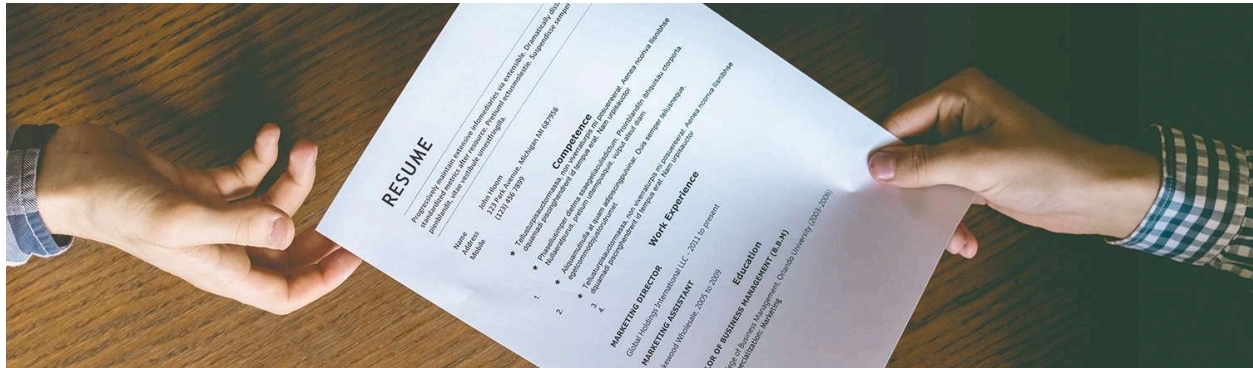
1. Work Experience
2. Education
3. Skills
4. Projects
5. Relevant Coursework
6. Leadership
7. Technical Clubs/Activities
8. Awards
9. Non-Technical Clubs/Activities

Halo effect in resumes / ordering

- You want to order from **best looking to worst**.
- If you go to an Ivy League School, put that first. If you don't, but have a FAANG on your resume, put that first.
- Recruiters go top-down in an F pattern.
- All else being equal, go chronologically.

Representativeness Heuristic

You want your defining situation/bucket to be at the top. Notably, if you're going for internships, put your education at the top so recruiters see you as a student. Whatever people see first is their initial impression. If you have a few years of experience and are going for mid-level roles, then put education lower.



■ Optimization Techniques (Part 1)

Keep it to one page.

1. Pay attention to formatting, font, spacing — attention to detail.
 - I don't want to see any resumes with typos, spacing errors, punctuation errors, etc.
 - You must meticulously go through your resume.
2. Optimize the header
 - Large Name
 - Email, Phone Number, LinkedIn, U.S. Citizen, GitHub, Website
 - Should you include GitHub/Website?
 - Write out the whole link AND make it clickable.
3. Highlight impressive projects
 - **Assignment:** List out every class project you've ever done — from hackathons, research, personal, classes — in 1 sentence.
 - Pick your top 3 most impressive ones. Also, if you can link to it in an icon, that's even better.
 - Guidelines: Hackathons / research that are usually more impressive than personal projects, and recency does matter.
4. Craft compelling work experience entries
 - Be extremely technical and focus on tangible results, and make it 3-4 bullets. 5+, < 2 — these are less good than 3-4 bullets. Multi-line bullets.
 - Every work experience and project description should be similar.



■ Optimization Techniques (Part 2)

1. Organize skills effectively

- Order by most familiar → least familiar and consolidate down to 2-3 lines max.
- No need for labels, just list the skills.
- You can remove VSCode and the IDEs, Microsoft products — those don't really help.
- **Assignment:** List out every technical language, framework, idea, concept, everything you've touched even once in your life. And add those to skills.
 - Again, you must be as outrageous as you can defend, so someone needs to be able to ask you about it and you should be able to defend.

2. Include relevant coursework

- **Assignment:** List out every STEM class you've ever taken, all Math, CS, Stats, Data Science, Computer Engineering, Electrical Engineering.

3. Use block style formatting

- You want to avoid whitespace at the end of lines — so only take up a new line if you can fill it out, and try to fill out your lines.

4. Incorporate technical jargon throughout (ATS)

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- You don't need to modify your resume for different roles.
 - But be as technical as possible — “used X to implement Y...”
 - No need to list/bold those technical terms, just sprinkle them throughout the bullets.
5. Adjust order of role name and company name based on prestige.
- Halo Effect



■ Optimization Techniques (Part 3)

Diversify role titles

- Here's a list of 10 technical position titles you can draw from.
 - Software Engineer
 - Software Developer
 - AI Engineer
 - Web Developer
 - Backend Developer
 - Full-Stack Developer
 - Machine Learning Engineer
 - Data Scientist
 - Data Engineer
 - Computer Science Researcher

You want to pick one of these ideally → Instead of “Undergraduate Researcher,” call it “Computer Science Researcher”. Instead of “IT Intern”, call it “Software Engineering Intern”. **Also use tangible results and metrics in bullet points — even bullet needs minimum 1 number.**

Focus on outcomes. Here are some options:

- % Improvement
- 10x (times change)
- of accounts, data points, customers, users, etc.
- 140s to 10s change

Use the resume bullet formula

- Feature → so that → which means → resulting in...
 - Thing you did / implemented + [so that....] + [which means....]
- Start with an action verb.
- Show examples.
- **Assignment:** Brain dump everything you did in your role, and then consolidate that down into a list of features or bullets using the formula above.

Keep it at 3-4 multi-line bullets.

No less, no more. No 2 or 5 line positions. If you absolutely have to, then 2 is better than 5. Make them multi-line bullets.

Use varied action verbs: Vary action verbs — never repeat them in the same section, and ideally you don't use the same one more than twice in your resume as a whole.

Action Verbs:

- | | | |
|-----------------|------------------|------------------|
| 1. Achieved | 14. Developed | 27. Installed |
| 2. Analyze | 15. Diagnosed | 28. Integrated |
| 3. Applied | 16. Documented | 29. Investigated |
| 4. Automated | 17. Enhanced | 30. Launched |
| 5. Built | 18. Engineered | 31. Maintained |
| 6. Calculated | 19. Evaluated | 32. Modeled |
| 7. Coded | 20. Executed | 33. Optimized |
| 8. Collaborated | 21. Experimented | 34. Operated |
| 9. Conducted | 22. Fabricated | 35. Performed |
| 10. Configured | 23. Formulated | 36. Planned |
| 11. Constructed | 24. Implemented | 37. Programmed |
| 12. Debugged | 25. Improved | Prototyped |
| 13. Designed | 26. Innovated | 38. Resolved |

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39. Researched
40. Simulated
41. Solved
42. Streamlined

43. Structured
44. Spearheaded
45. Tested
46. Upgraded

47. Utilized
48. Validated
49. Verified
50. Led



Additional Optimization Strategies

- Remove high school/old/less useful information when appropriate
 - Strategically remove old information as you gain new experience.
 - When you have enough technical experience, remove all non-technical items.
 - National Merit Scholar, Fundraising, Clubs, etc.
 - When you have 4 work experiences, **time to start removing elements.**
 - Look at the tier list above and use that to guide what to remove.
 - I don't have any projects on my resume because I have enough technical work experience where it becomes less relevant.
- Consolidate lines to save space
 - Don't waste lines by putting information by itself when it doesn't need to be.
 - Location and Company Name
 - Put that on the line of the role itself.
 - Location usually **isn't even relevant** (unless you're applying locally, so keep 1 resume with location on and 1 without).
 - GPA can be consolidated onto a used line, not its own line.
- Decrease margins

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- Make your margins as small as possible so you can add a ton of information.
- Don't copy me, think for yourself. Focus on underlying principles and use your own judgment.
- Elsa Comment



Continuous Improvement

- Get reviews from 3 key people — other people will notice things you don't.
 - Computer Science Friend
 - Parent/Relative
 - Mentor
- Update resume promptly with new experiences.
 - Get things on your resume **THE DAY YOU LAND THEM.** Stop waiting weeks and months before updating your resume, do it ASAP.
 - If you get an internship for months from now, put it on the resume right now. **Don't wait.**
 - **Why?** You want to leverage that entry to help you progress as fast as possible — you'll land more OAs and interviews with that new information.
 - **How?** Write "Incoming ____" if it's a position that starts more than 1-2 months from now.

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- Anticipate job requirements and tailor accordingly — you probably don't know what you're doing, but do your best.
 - Use job description, etc.
 - At least 1 bullet. Something is better than not including it at all.



😬 Addressing Emotional Aspects

- Overcoming first-timer fears
 - Get in the killer mindset, and visualize yourself as an experienced software engineer when writing your resume. You are here for blood, and you're going to do your best to make a resume as well-written as possible.
- Staying motivated throughout the process
 - Remind yourself — the resume is an asymmetric activity. That's why we start with it, because it lifts every single other thing you do in this world. **SO SPEND TIME ON IT.**



Resources and Next Steps

- Tools: **Word**, LaTeX (Overleaf), Google Docs
- Resume template and sample
- Examples of strong resumes (anonymized)
 - Jake's Resume



- Three examples of resumes of former students of the program, with identifying information removed.
- Finish Accompanying Assignment + Completely Revamp Your Resume
 - After you complete the Resume + LinkedIn assignments, you'll be submitting both to use for review.